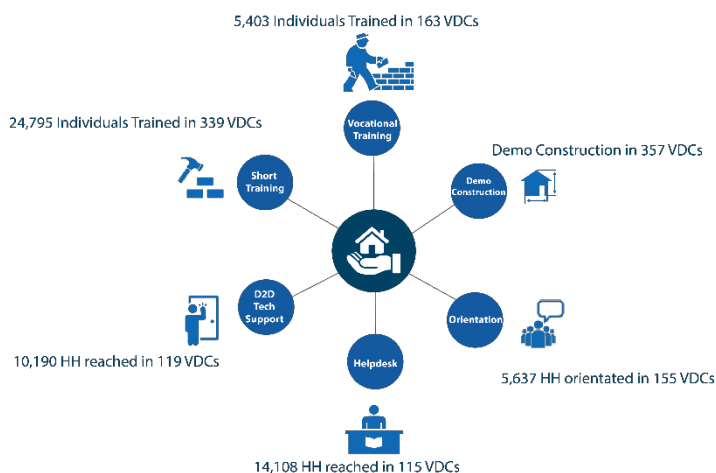


HRRP General Meeting Dhoikhama Café, 21st April 2017

Participants: NRA, CAFOD, Trocaire, INF Nepal, Kam For Sud, MoUD CL-PIU, EWDE-DKH, World Renew, Asia Foundation, NOMAD, ACTED, TGH, Mercy Corps, Radio Sagarmatha, Chaudhary Foundation, UN RCO, USAID, MoFALD CL-PIU, Centum Learning, FinnChurch Aid, British Red Cross, Nepal Youth Foundation, Save the Children, ARSOW Nepal, NSET, Oxfam, SOS Children's Villages Nepal, Mission Aviation Fellowship, JICA (TPIS-ERP), Tdh Nepal Foundation, Medair, IFRC, United Mission Nepal, CORDAID, UNDP, VSO / NDRCS, Habitat for Humanity, ActionAid Nepal, CRS, Swisscontact, PSB Nepal, Help-EV, Build Up Nepal, MoFALD DL-PIU Kathmandu, DFID, Thecho Mahala Saccos, ASF Nepal, Norwegian Red Cross, Helvetas, Concern Worldwide, Miyamoto, Samaritan's Purse, IFMR, Harvard, Welt Hunger Hilfe, Lumanti, Solidar, Mero FM, and Radio Jamasara.

HRRP, Loren Lockwood, National Coordinator

Provided an overview of HRRP and the reconstruction context including the presence of different typologies and solutions, and different technical issues, across various geographical areas highlights that a blanket approach to Technical Assistance (TA) and standards is not possible.



Updated on POs progress to date implementing the minimum package of 6 TA activities, and highlighted that TA should be much broader than this. However, the urgent need is to get the minimum package right first. In the absence of this, the chance of compliant construction is very low.

Some of the major successes and challenges in the provision of TA were presented. Partner Organisations (POs) were urged to ensure that their TA activities run for the long term as the reconstruction process still has years to go. If TA programmes finish now there will be huge part of the affected population that will miss out on TA.

HRRP recommended next steps including adjusting programmes to move funds from the housing reconstruction grant (which is covered by the GoN) to technical assistance and / or vulnerable top-up grants, expanding support to the 17 districts, and facilitating set up and strengthening of Community Reconstruction Committees (CRCs). HRRP also urged POs to increase support to the MoUD DL-PIU engineers and VDC staff to support information flow and ensure common understanding and approach amongst all stakeholders and across all areas. Simply deploying additional engineers to the field will not be a solution if they don't have the skills to communicate with households, and don't have the correct information to communicate. Markets / vendors are a critical part of this and could easily provide a lot of information to households to build stronger houses if we can support them to do this.

Mishri Kayastha, Survivor of 1934 and 2015 Earthquakes, Lalitpur, 'Reminiscence of the Great Earthquake'

MoFALD CL-PIU, Narayan Prasad Shrestha, Deputy Project Director

MoFALD CL-PIU provided a status update on enrolment and grievances (of 207,723 registered, 118,725 have been dealt with). An MIS update showed that across the districts an average of 75% of Programme Agreements (PAs) have been

digitised. The low numbers in Sindhupalchowk and Gorkha result from recruitment of MIS staff being delayed but MIS staff will be in these districts from 22nd April so progress will be seen on this soon.

In the 17 districts 91,677 households have so far been declared eligible to receive the 300,000 NPRs reconstruction grant. Further data from the damage assessment is being finalised by the Central Bureau of Statistics (CBS). 175 HHs have been enrolled and 67 have received the first tranche.

It has been challenging to get the signed PAs from VDC to DDC (one copy goes to the household and one to the VDC) but now budget has been approved to move these from the VDC to DDC and this will be completed as soon as possible. Another challenge is the digitisation of PAs, only 46 VDCs in Dhading and 16 in Nuwakot have completed this. MoFALD CL-PIU have requested NRA and MoUD to upload the data stored on the tablets to support with this.

MoFALD CL-PIU have developed an Environmental and Social Management Framework (ESMF) which is available [here](#).

Sunil Thapa, DL-PIU Engineer, Ramechhap, 'An Engineer's Perspective'

MoUD CL-PIU, Parikshit Kadariya, Deputy Project Director

An update was provided on technical standards and staffing for the housing reconstruction. There have been serious challenges because of the high turnover of the field engineers and MoUD CL-PIU have had an open call to try to fill the vacant positions but it is difficult. Turnover is much lower amongst the sub-engineers and assistant sub-engineers. Technical assistance, including awareness raising programmes, masons training, and door to door technical assistance are very important to help households with their reconstruction.

Some successes include publishing Volume 2 of the design catalogue (households may prepare their own designs as per NBC), preparing the 'Corrections and Exceptions' Manual, and preparing type designs for RCC buildings that could not be approved under the Mandatory Rules of Thumb (MRTs). Building by-laws for traditional settlements have also been approved and are in the process of being printed in the national gazette, core areas in Kathmandu and outside will benefit. In late Dec 2016, the cabinet enforced the NBC in all municipalities and VDCs with more than 1,000 HHs.

Some challenges include not having regular and adequate funding (e.g. for OJT in gap VDCs), availability and quality of masons that are being produced (e.g. training conducted in 2 days instead of 7), supply chain and quality of materials, addressing technical standards for all typologies, duplication of activities (some areas have many POs present and duplication is an issue), and high rate of non-compliance. Technical assistance is very important to address non-compliances but need to take care to disseminate the correct information, e.g. Shelter Cluster 10 key messages leaflets do not cover all compliance criteria. Some photos of good and bad construction practices seen in the districts were also presented.

Sapana Shah, RADO Nepal Engineer, Makwanpur, 'Sapana's Dream'

NRA, Bishma Bhusal, Deputy Spokesperson

Mr. Bhusal requested participants not to be confused with some of the differences in figures presented and informed that the differences will be addressed.

An update was provided on the grievance process, training (mobilisation of army), mobilisation of engineering students (to collect data on construction status and provide households with information), resettlement, schools (approximately 100 type designs have been approved but funding is required for reconstruction of 2/3 of school buildings), historically important buildings, and heritage sites. The budget expenditure to date was also presented. Total expenditure last year

was lower than expected as the framework was just being established. This year progress has been much better. The ministry / agency wise budget allocation and expenditure to date was presented and 45% has been spent.

Mr. Bhusal had spent the previous month in Hawaii doing a Disaster Management training course and the other participants had heard that the relief activities in Nepal went well but had a negative perception of the reconstruction activities. He requested all partners to work together to set a different standard and show everyone that Nepal can do this. The NRA are trying to expedite the works and learn from past mistakes, and any problems that partners face at NRA can be raised with Mr. Bhusal. POs were also requested to submit activity reports for the NRA's 2 year anniversary communications.

Ayush Baskota, Baliyo Ghar District Coordinator Nuwakot, 'One Step at a Time'

NRA, Dr. Govind Raj Pokharel, CEO

The NRA CEO, Dr. Govind Raj Pokharel, closed the meeting with the following points:

- Partner Organisations (POs) are urgently requested to expand coverage of technical assistance. Households need information and guidance so that they can effectively manage their reconstruction; money and materials alone will not ensure construction of compliant houses. The NRA does not need POs to cover the reconstruction grant, and can support POs to amend their projects to change from the grant to TA. Communicate simple facts about standards, using simple language.
- Avoid training same people multiple times, take care when selecting participants.
- Provide support to households for preparation and approval of house designs as per their needs. Several POs are working on this but it needs to be scaled up.
- Corrective measures will be required to address non-compliances and the standards described in the [Corrections and Exceptions Manual](#) will need to be disseminated effectively amongst households.
- Retrofitting solutions need to be developed to preserve traditional architecture styles and households' / communities' identities. One solution is not fit for all areas; different cultural and regional contexts need to be considered in terms of housing design and architecture. POs are requested to support with development of technical solutions to preserve and promote traditional housing typologies.
- The NGO mobilisation guidelines have been updated so that if the GoN has provided first tranche of the reconstruction grant an I/NGO can provide the 2nd and / or 3rd tranche. POs are however requested to avoid investment in the grant as this is covered by the GoN.
- NRA should approve all NGOs within 7 working days of receiving application. Once approved at national level POs will need to get approval from the relevant district offices. This is to avoid duplication and will be a simple process where the PO provides a letter from central NRA to the CDO and relevant government authorities.
- Households displaced by geo-hazards will be able to access a 200,000 NPRs grant to purchase land somewhere else if their land has been found to be unsafe to return to under the geo-hazard risk assessment conducted by NRA. Landless people will be able to access a 200,000 NPRs grant from the GoN to purchase land somewhere else (if they don't own land somewhere else). So far 9,420 families have been identified to be in this situation.
- NRA is considering potential options to keep migrant labourers in the country for at least 2 months before they travel so that they can work on the reconstruction.
- POs are requested to consider hiring trained masons as part of door to door technical assistance teams. This will have more impact than hiring an engineer and several masons can be hired with the money required for an engineer's salary.

Dr. Govind Raj Pokharel, NRA CEO, 'A Step Towards Rebuilding Nepal'

Q&A

The first six questions were collected from communities by the [Common Feedback Project](#) and [BBC Media Action](#).

Q: We heard that NRA has decided to give 200,000 NPR to purchase the land for those households whose land has been identified as at risk. Does it mean they must pay for the land first and then get back the money back, or will they get it in advance?

They must find land which is registered with the Land Reform and Revenue Office and they are looking at developing a modality where when they are registering the land in their name they will receive the 200,000 NPRs from the NRA.

Q: 25,000 NPRs of the third tranche is linked to having a toilet and solar panels, is it mandatory to install solar panels?

The toilet is mandatory, solar panels are not.

Q: We heard a rumour that the GoN are not going to give out the remaining tranches of the grant, is this true?

If your house is constructed in compliance with the technical standards you will receive the remaining tranches.

Q: We heard that if we have made a mistake during construction we will be disqualified from receiving the grant, is that true?

No, if there are mistakes corrective measures must be taken to rectify the construction so that it meets the technical standards. Once this is completed they will receive the subsequent tranche.

Q: We heard a rumour that people who build timber houses will not receive the second instalment, is this true?

A timber house design is part of [volume 2 of the DUDBC design catalogue](#). If households follow these technical standards and specifications, they will be able to receive the second tranche.

Q: I heard a rumour that the engineers will not approve our houses if we do not give them money, is this true?

No, this is definitely not true. The CEO informed that he has called all CDOs in the earthquake affected districts and asked them to be very strict and to take action against employees if they are not doing their work properly.

Q: Hari Devkota, Nomad – where are we lacking in relation to Disaster Management in comparison to other countries and what are the things we need to improve on?

Originally the NRA was planned more along the lines of the Gujarat and Pakistan models but now it is like a ministry and the idea to make the NRA more independent and autonomous has failed. Another issue is the failure to mobilise the reconstruction funds; it is not the fault of the Ministry of Finance but it hasn't worked to have to follow these processes. It is also challenging that very few POs are flexible and will not adjust / expand working areas and activities. Whilst the act cannot be changed the structure and ways of working can be changed to address these challenges and the CEO informed that he is feeling positive about the way forward.

Q: Laxmi from Thecho – in Thecho there are more than 1,200 houses that are fully damaged. The majority were built on a small plot of land and they are unable to reconstruct because the municipality by laws do not allow construction on such small plots. People cannot afford to buy a new plot of land. Are there any options for them to get permission to construct their houses on these small plots?

Dr. Pokharel informed that he has been greatly influenced by Newari culture and when he was NRA CEO in 2015 he visited one Newari community to try to work with them to preserve their traditional architecture. He is planning to work on this further and to look at the challenges and potential solutions around the land issues raised.

Q: In Rasuwa most buildings are dry stone masonry but there is no provision for this typology under the inspection process or the [Nepal National Building Code \(NBC\)](#). What are the government's plans to address this?

MoUD CL-PIU informed that DUDBC has already reviewed a 2.5 storey dry stone masonry model but it was found to be unsafe in terms of seismic load. Hence from an engineering point of view the model could not be recommended.

Work is ongoing in this area to research potential correction measures to strengthen dry stone masonry houses which are common across all [northern areas](#).

Q: Where a reconstructed home is found to be non-compliant, is it possible to send an expert team to analyse the strength of the building? or pending New reconstruct houses, If it possible to send expert team to analyze strength of building?

NRA is doing in some cases.

Q: Many organisations have designed different buildings for different contexts. Does the government have any provision to approve these designs?

Yes, designs should be submitted to MoUD CL-PIU (moudclpiu@gmail.com) for review and if the design is compliant with the [Nepal National Building Code](#) it will be approved and households can choose to rebuild using these designs.

Reference Documents

- [Nepal Earthquake 2015: Housing reconstruction Two Years On](#)
- HRRP 4W [Dataset](#) and [Dashboard](#)
- [Technical Assistance Coverage Maps](#)

Contact Details

Contact details for the presenters are provided below to facilitate follow up on any of the topics covered in the session.

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